

The Department Can See. Now It Must Decide.

An Operational Reflection on the Next Phase of Zero Trust

One of the most interesting things about the current state of Zero Trust is not what people are talking about.

It is what they are not talking about.

Recently I listened to a panel discussion featuring senior leaders from across the Department of Defense Zero Trust ecosystem.

The discussion covered many familiar topics.

Identity.

ICAM.

Federation.

Telemetry.

Visibility.

AI.

Automation.

Thunderdome.

DODNet.

All important subjects.

All worthy investments.

And yet throughout the discussion, I kept waiting for another topic to appear.

Authorization.

It never really did.

This is not a criticism of the panel.

In many ways, the discussion accurately reflected where the Department currently sits on its Zero Trust journey.

We have spent years building the ability to know things.

The next challenge is deciding things.

That distinction matters more than many people realize.

Over the last several years, the Department has made enormous progress in attribution.

We know far more about who is attempting to access systems than we did just a few years ago.

Identity providers have matured.

Federation has expanded.

Authentication has become stronger.

Conditional access capabilities continue to improve.

The ability to answer:

"Who is this?"

has improved dramatically.

The Department has also made enormous progress in visibility.

We collect telemetry from endpoints, networks, applications, cloud services, identities, and security platforms at a scale that would have been difficult to imagine a decade ago.

We can see more than ever.

We can observe more than ever.

We can measure more than ever.

The ability to answer:

"What is happening?"

has improved dramatically.

Yet one question remains surprisingly difficult.

"What should happen next?"

That is an authorization problem.

Not an authentication problem.

Not an identity problem.

Not a telemetry problem.

An authorization problem.

At enterprise scale, authorization becomes one of the most difficult architectural challenges in cybersecurity.

Every future capability currently being discussed ultimately depends on answering that question well.

AI agents depend on it.

Conditional access depends on it.

Mission-based access depends on it.

Automated response depends on it.

Dynamic policy depends on it.

Continuous evaluation depends on it.

Even autonomous decision-making ultimately depends on authorization.

The irony is that attribution and visibility often dominate discussions because they are easier to see.

Identity systems are visible.

Telemetry platforms are visible.

Dashboards are visible.

Authorization is different.

Authorization lives inside:

- policy models
- decision engines
- trust relationships
- governance structures
- business logic
- mission context
- enforcement architectures

It is less visible.

But it is where trust becomes action.

Knowing who someone is does not tell you what they should be allowed to do.

Seeing activity does not tell you what should happen next.

Authorization sits between those two worlds.

It transforms information into decisions.

This is why I increasingly view the current state of Zero Trust through a simple progression:

Identity tells us who.

Visibility tells us what is happening.

Authorization determines what happens next.

The Department has invested heavily in the first two.

The third remains significantly harder.

Not because the technology does not exist.

Because authorization is fundamentally an architectural problem.

It requires consistent policy models.

Clear authority boundaries.

Trustworthy attributes.

Decision governance.

Enterprise-scale policy management.

Runtime enforcement.

And perhaps most importantly, agreement on who is allowed to make which decisions under which conditions.

Those are difficult problems.

Much harder than deploying another sensor.

Much harder than collecting another telemetry feed.

Much harder than buying another product.

This may be why many organizations find themselves surrounded by identities, telemetry, analytics, dashboards, and automation platforms while still struggling to make consistent authorization decisions.

The challenge is no longer collecting information.

The challenge is transforming information into trustworthy action.

That is where architecture begins to matter more than products.

The most valuable observation I took away from the discussion was not a new technology.

It was a validation of where the Department appears to be heading.

The conversation is increasingly focused on:

- capability over compliance
- outcomes over activities
- telemetry over perimeter
- automation over manual operations
- shared services over bespoke implementations

Those are all positive developments.

But they also point toward the next major challenge.

The Department has spent years learning how to see.

The next phase of Zero Trust depends on learning how to decide.

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“Asymmetric Precision”